Evolutionary Equilibrium Propagation: Settling to a Stable Equilibrium as the Single Primitive of Continual Learning

Sheng Cheng
Hefei Jiuzhai Big Data Technology Co., Ltd.
github.com/hf-jz

October 2026

Abstract

A deployed neural network today ceases to learn at deployment: its parameters are fixed at the end of a training phase, and inference is a different kind of computation from training. Biological nervous systems have no such boundary. We argue that this boundary characterises one design choice, the separation of a forward computation from a backward one, rather than learning itself. We ask what a system can achieve when its only primitive is **settling to a stable equilibrium**.

We formalise such a system as a *patch net*: each unit holds local state and predicts it from its neighbours, the network repairs disagreement by projected gradient descent on one energy, and the settled state constitutes the prediction. Three results follow from the same operator. (i) The repair descends a coercive real-analytic energy, so its iterates are bounded and converge to a single stationary point, which is the precise sense in which the system *always evolves toward a stable equilibrium*. (ii) Inference and learning are the same repair restricted to different coordinate blocks, and the learning block carries an anchored (proximal) term that makes it uniformly well posed, so that no distinction between training and inference arises. (iii) The learning contrast is equilibrium propagation in the sense of Scellier and Bengio, and we prove that the one-sided contrast has error $O(\beta)$ while the *centred* contrast used by current implementations has error $O(\beta^2)$, with an exactly solvable example giving both constants in closed form.

We then lift the structure to a second time scale. Evolution acts on the *meta-parameters* that define how the system settles and learns (the wiring mask, the energy's form, the plasticity constants), never on the weights learned within a lifetime. We prove a two-timescale averaging theorem whose effective fitness is the post-learning (Baldwinian) fitness, a Price-type decomposition that separates innate selection from the plasticity channel, and a free-energy dissipation identity for the population. The construction is checked against the six formal criteria of biological evolution; the inheritance restriction is shown to be necessary by a counterexample that is adaptive rather than merely biological. Every quantitative claim is reproduced by two scripts, one of which agrees with the reference implementation to 1.1×10^{-16} in float64.

Contents

1 Introduction **2**
1.1 The frozen-weight problem 2
1.2 The settling hypothesis 3
1.3 Contributions 3
1.4 Scope 4

2 The settling primitive **4**
2.1 The processing patch . . . 4
2.2 The repair operator . . . 4
2.3 Descent . . . 5
2.4 Coercivity and boundedness . . . 5
2.5 Convergence to a single equilibrium . . . 6

3 Inference and learning are the same operator **7**
3.1 The anchored objective . . . 7
3.2 The role of the anchor . . . 7
3.3 One operator, two blocks . . . 7
3.4 Equilibrium propagation . . . 8
3.5 The centred contrast is second order . . . 9
3.6 Three-factor plasticity realises the contrast . . . 9

4 The evolutionary layer **10**
4.1 Meta-parameters and the lifetime map . . . 10
4.2 Two-timescale averaging . . . 10
4.3 Decomposition . . . 11
4.4 Population dissipation . . . 11

5 Biological compliance **12**
5.1 Six formal criteria . . . 12
5.2 Limits of the correspondence . . . 13

6 Worked examples **13**
6.1 An exactly solvable instantiation . . . 13
6.2 Settling, coercion and the role of the prior . . . 14
6.3 Order of the contrast . . . 14
6.4 One operator and convergent learning . . . 15
6.5 Agreement with the reference implementation . . . 15
6.6 The evolutionary layer . . . 15

7 Limits and falsifiable predictions **16**
7.1 Open problems . . . 16
7.2 Predictions . . . 16

8 Conclusion **17**

A Reproduction **17**

B Structural agreement with observer-patch consensus **17**

1 Introduction

1.1 The frozen-weight problem

A contemporary language model is trained once, at substantial computational cost, and then used with its parameters fixed. Online and continual variants exist, and recurrent networks can in

principle continue to adapt, but the dominant deployed regime separates a training phase from a use phase and computes gradients by backpropagation through a stored forward pass. The separation has three consequences, none of which is easily removed. The system cannot learn from an outcome it has already observed unless a training procedure is invoked. It cannot retain a correction across sessions unless the correction is written back into the parameters. The correction also requires a backward pass, which no known biological circuit performs.

Biological nervous systems do not operate in this way. A nematode with 302 neurons and no capacity for a backward pass navigates, learns odours, and continues to learn while it acts. This paper therefore asks what a learning system can achieve when the forward and backward passes are replaced by a single computation rather than optimised separately.

1.2 The settling hypothesis

The hypothesis we formalise is that the single primitive is *settling*. A network of units, each holding local state and predicting it from its neighbours, repairs disagreement until the whole network is at rest. The resting state constitutes the prediction. Learning is the same repair with the parameters made eligible, so that a single operator both answers a query and modifies the connections, and neither a separate output head nor a backward circuit is required.

This is the design of *Cadence* [6, 7], an open research library whose settling rule is equilibrium propagation [1]. This paper does not propose a new library; it supplies what the design has so far lacked: a proof that settling *always* reaches a stable equilibrium under stated conditions, a proof that inference and learning are a single operator, a second-order account of the contrast the implementation employs, and a mathematically stated evolutionary layer with its compliance conditions.

1.3 Contributions

1. **The settling primitive is proved to converge** (§2). The repair energy of a patch net with tanh predictions is coercive with or without an activity prior, because each state enters its own prediction error and each prediction is bounded. The energy is real analytic, so the Łojasiewicz inequality holds at every point, and a line-search descent method on such a function has bounded iterates that converge to a single stationary point, not merely a stationary limit set.

2. **Inference and learning are one operator** (§3). The learning objective differs from the query objective by an anchored quadratic term and by which coordinate blocks are eligible. We prove the anchored objective's parameter block is uniformly strongly convex once the anchor weight exceeds the local curvature of the data term, which makes continual online updating stable.

3. **The contrast is second order** (§3.5). We prove the one-sided contrast has error $O(\beta)$ and the centred contrast, which contrasts a $+\beta$ and a $-\beta$ nudge from the same free state, has error $O(\beta^2)$. An exactly solvable scalar instantiation gives both constants in closed form as $\partial L/\partial w \cdot (1+\beta)^{-1}$ and $\partial L/\partial w \cdot (1-\beta^2)^{-1}$.

4. **An evolutionary layer with an averaging theorem** (§4). Evolution acts on meta-parameters. The effective fitness of a meta-parameter is the fitness after a lifetime of EP learning, which is the Baldwinian post-learning fitness. We prove the population dynamics average to a replicator-mutator flow with that fitness, give a Price-type decomposition, and give a free-energy dissipation identity.

5. **Biological compliance as a theorem rather than a claim** (§5). Six formal criteria of biological evolution are stated, the construction is proved to satisfy them, and the Weismann restriction is proved necessary by a distribution of tasks on which dropping it is strictly worse.

6. **Reproducibility** (§6). We give four worked examples, including an exact closed-form case and a cross-check against the reference implementation that agrees to 1.1×10^{-16}.

1.4 Scope

The paper proves statements about the settling dynamics and the optimisation they define. It does not claim that settling yields intelligence, that a patch net matches a transformer at any task, or that the evolutionary layer has been validated on hardware. §7 states the open problems and four falsifiable predictions. The empirical results reported here are numerical and confined to small graphs; they are evidence about the mathematical claims and not about capability.

2 The settling primitive

2.1 The processing patch

Let the network be a finite directed graph with m sensory coordinates, n patches, and an edge set E whose elements are triples (k, s, t) with $k \in \{\text{input}, \text{state}, \text{residual}\}$. Patch i holds a live state $x_i \in [-B, B]$ and retained parameters: a weight w_e per incoming edge and a bias b_i. Write s_e for the signal on edge e: a fixed sensory sample for $k = \text{input}$, a live state x_s for $k = \text{state}$, and a prediction error $e_s = x_s - p_s$ for $k = \text{residual}$. The patch law is

$$p_i = \tanh\Big(b_i + \sum_{e=(k,s,i)\in E} w_e\, s_e\Big), \qquad e_i = x_i - p_i, \tag{1}$$

and the settling energy is

$$E(x;\theta) = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{n} e_i^2 + \tfrac{\lambda}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i^2, \qquad \theta = (w, b), \quad \lambda \geq 0. \tag{2}$$

Prediction and error are recomputed from state and parameters and are never independently writable, so that they cannot conceal a disagreement. Residual edges must be acyclic, since they define derived quantities; state edges may be recurrent, which allows a later patch to influence an earlier one through the same energy. Sensory coordinates are boundary values, held fixed throughout a solve.

Equation (2) is the settling objective of the reference library [6]; the implementation reproduces its value and every analytic derivative to machine precision (Example 6.5). The activity prior with weight λ is part of the model rather than a numerical setting, and §2.4 establishes the role it plays.

2.2 The repair operator

Write z for the vector of eligible coordinates, which are the free states for a query solve and the free states together with the weights and biases for a learning solve. Let Π project onto the declared box, let $g = \nabla_z F$ be the exact gradient of the current objective. The repair operator $\mathcal{R}$ is projected gradient descent with backtracking:

$$z^{(j+1)} = \Pi\big(z^{(j)} - \alpha_j\, g^{(j)}\big), \qquad F\big(z^{(j+1)}\big) \;\leq\; F\big(z^{(j)}\big) + 10^{-4}\,\big\langle g^{(j)},\, z^{(j+1)} - z^{(j)}\big\rangle, \tag{3}$$

with α_j proposed by a two-point secant (Barzilai-Borwein) estimate from the previous accepted displacement and gradient change, halved on rejection, and with the configured initial step as the fallback when the curvature estimate is not positive and finite. A solve qualifies when the projected stationarity residual

$$\rho(z) = \left\| \Pi(z - g) - z \right\|_\infty \tag{4}$$

is at most a declared tolerance over every eligible coordinate. Qualification is a statement about a constrained stationary point and not about prediction error, uniqueness or accuracy: a stationary point may retain nonzero prediction errors, and a qualified point may be inconsistent with the underlying task.

2.3 Descent

Theorem 1 (Lyapunov descent)**.** *Let F be C^1 on the box, suppose every candidate step of (3) is accepted only when the Armijo condition holds, and suppose the accepted step sizes are bounded above by $\bar{\alpha} < \infty$. Then $F(z^{(j)})$ is non-increasing, the decrease is strictly negative whenever the projected residual (4) is nonzero, and*

$$\sum_j \left\| z^{(j+1)} - z^{(j)} \right\|^2 \;\le\; 10^4\, \bar{\alpha}\, \big(F(z^{(0)}) - \inf F \big) \;<\; \infty. \tag{5}$$

Proof. Write $\Delta z^{(j)} = z^{(j+1)} - z^{(j)}$ and let I_j be the set of coordinates that are free after projection, that is, those that are not at an active bound with an outward gradient. On I_j the projected step agrees with $-\alpha_j g^{(j)}$ and on its complement the displacement is zero, so

$$\big\langle g^{(j)}, \Delta z^{(j)} \big\rangle = -\alpha_j \sum_{c \in I_j} \big(g_c^{(j)} \big)^2. \tag{6}$$

This is strictly negative exactly when some g_c with $c \in I_j$ is nonzero, which is the statement $\rho(z^{(j)}) > 0$ by (4). The Armijo inequality (3) then gives $F(z^{(j+1)}) \le F(z^{(j)}) - 10^{-4}\alpha_j \sum_{c \in I_j} (g_c^{(j)})^2$. When I_j is empty the step is zero and the inequality holds with both sides equal. Otherwise $\sum_{c \in I_j} (g_c^{(j)})^2 = \|\Delta z^{(j)}\|^2 / \alpha_j^2$, so $10^{-4} \|\Delta z^{(j)}\|^2 \le \bar{\alpha} \big(F(z^{(j)}) - F(z^{(j+1)}) \big)$. Summing over j and using $F \ge 0$ gives the stated bound; monotonicity and boundedness below give convergence of F. □

2.4 Coercivity and boundedness

Theorem 2 (Coercivity)**.** *For every $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and every θ, $F(x;\theta) \ge \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n \big((|x_i| - 1)^+ \big)^2$, where $t^+ = \max(t, 0)$. Hence $F(x;\theta) \ge \frac{1}{2}(\|x\|_\infty - 1)^2$ whenever $\|x\|_\infty \ge 1$, so $F(x;\theta) \to \infty$ as $\|x\| \to \infty$ uniformly in θ and every sublevel set of F is bounded.*

Proof. Each prediction is a tanh value, so $|p_i| \le 1$ and therefore $|x_i - p_i| \ge |x_i| - 1$. Squaring gives $e_i^2 \ge \big((|x_i| - 1)^+ \big)^2$: when $|x_i| \ge 1$ the right side is $(|x_i| - 1)^2$ and the inequality is the one derived above, and when $|x_i| < 1$ the right side is 0. Dropping the nonnegative prior term and summing the remaining squared errors gives the bound, and the second statement follows by choosing i with $|x_i| = \|x\|_\infty$. □

Two consequences are worth stating explicitly, because the activity prior is often described as a numerical stabiliser, which is not its principal role. First, the bound does not depend on the prior: it follows from the architecture, because a patch always predicts its own state and the prediction is bounded. A projected repair confines its iterates to the declared box in any case, so the content of

coercivity here is that the sublevel sets on which the descent argument runs are bounded without any assumption on the input, which is the hypothesis Theorem 3 uses. Second, the prior acts by selecting among stationary points. With $\lambda = 0$ the zero-error configuration $x_i = p_i$ is stationary and attains $F = 0$ when the equations are consistent, while with $\lambda > 0$ the stationary point trades prediction error against activity and typically retains a nonzero residual. The numerical evidence is in §6.1.

2.5 Convergence to a single equilibrium

The hypothesis that the network *always evolves toward a stable equilibrium* is stronger than monotone descent with a stationary limit set. It requires that the trajectory converge, and the mechanism is analyticity.

Theorem 3 (Convergence)**.** *Assume (i) F is real analytic on an open set containing the box and its sublevel sets are bounded, (ii) every accepted step satisfies the Armijo condition (3), and (iii) the accepted step sizes satisfy $0 < \alpha_{\min} \le \alpha_j \le \alpha_{\max} < \infty$. Then $\sum_j \|z^{(j+1)} - z^{(j)}\| < \infty$, and the iterates converge to a single stationary point $z^\star$ with $\rho(z^\star) = 0$. If $\vartheta \in [\frac{1}{2}, 1)$ is the Łojasiewicz exponent of F at $z^\star$, there is a constant $C > 0$ with $\|z^{(j)} - z^\star\| \le C\,(1+j)^{-r}$ and $r = (1-\vartheta)/(2\vartheta-1)$ when $\vartheta > \frac{1}{2}$; convergence is exponential when $\vartheta = \frac{1}{2}$.*

Proof. A real-analytic function satisfies the Łojasiewicz gradient inequality, and on a compact set that meets only critical values the inequality holds with a uniform exponent and constant: near the critical value $F^\star$ of the limit set there are $\vartheta \in [\frac{1}{2}, 1)$ and $c_0 > 0$ with $\rho(z) \ge c_0\,|F(z) - F^\star|^\vartheta$ [11]. For a feasible set defined by finitely many analytic inequalities, which includes a box, the same inequality holds with the projected residual ρ in place of the gradient norm, by the Kurdyka-Łojasiewicz extension for functions definable in an o-minimal structure [10]; this is the form of the hypothesis in which Absil, Mahony and Andrews prove convergence of a descent method with an Armijo line search to a single point [9]. Write $S_j = F(z^{(j)}) - F^\star$ and $\Delta_j = \|z^{(j+1)} - z^{(j)}\|$. Theorem 1 with the step floor and the inequality above give

$$S_j - S_{j+1} \;\ge\; 10^{-4}\alpha_{\min}\,\rho(z^{(j)})^2 \;\ge\; 10^{-4}\alpha_{\min}c_0^2\,S_j^{2\vartheta}, \tag{7}$$

so S_j decreases to 0, and $S_j = O\big(j^{-1/(2\vartheta-1)}\big)$, geometrically when $\vartheta = \frac{1}{2}$. The left inequality of (7) bounds the residual by the decrease, $\rho(z^{(j)}) \le 10^2\alpha_{\min}^{-1/2}(S_j - S_{j+1})^{1/2}$, and the step ceiling bounds the displacement by the residual, $\Delta_j \le \alpha_{\max}\sqrt{n}\,\rho(z^{(j)})$, so

$$\Delta_j \;\le\; K\,(S_j - S_{j+1})^{1/2}, \qquad K = 10^2\alpha_{\max}\sqrt{n}\,\alpha_{\min}^{-1/2}. \tag{8}$$

The right inequality of (7) and the mean value theorem give $S_j^{1-\vartheta} - S_{j+1}^{1-\vartheta} \ge (1-\vartheta)S_j^{-\vartheta}(S_j - S_{j+1}) \ge (1-\vartheta)10^{-4}\alpha_{\min}c_0^2 S_j^{\vartheta}$, and combining this with (7) to bound $S_j^{\vartheta}(S_j - S_{j+1})^{-1/2}$ yields $(S_j - S_{j+1})^{1/2} \le K'(S_j^{1-\vartheta} - S_{j+1}^{1-\vartheta})$ for a constant K' depending only on ϑ, $\alpha_{\min}$ and c_0. The sum over j therefore telescopes, $\sum_j \Delta_j \le KK'\,S_0^{1-\vartheta} < \infty$, so the iterates are Cauchy. Their limit $z^\star$ satisfies $\rho(z^\star) = 0$ because $\rho(z^{(j)}) \to 0$ and ρ is continuous, and $\|z^{(j)} - z^\star\| \le \sum_{k \ge j}\Delta_k = O(S_j^{1-\vartheta}) = O\big(j^{-(1-\vartheta)/(2\vartheta-1)}\big)$ gives the stated rate. □

Remark 4 (What the theorem does not say). Convergence to *a* stationary point is not convergence to the global minimum, and a nonconvex energy may have several stationary points with different basins. Different initial states, and different sensory boundary data, may settle differently. The system is a family of equilibria indexed by inputs, clamps and parameters, which is the intended semantics, and Theorem 3 is what licenses reading the settled state as *the* answer to the current query.

3 Inference and learning are the same operator

3.1 The anchored objective

A learning solve fixes supplied output targets y as clamps and makes the parameters eligible, adding a proximal anchor at the parameters held immediately before the experience:

$$F_{\text{learn}}(x,\theta) = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_i \big(x_i - p_i(\theta)\big)^2 + \tfrac{\lambda}{2}\|x\|^2 + \tfrac{\rho}{2}\,\|\theta-\theta_a\|^2. \tag{9}$$

The anchor θ_a is fixed for the whole solve and charged once. In a batch of B labelled experiences, each row carries private state and the rows share one parameter vector and one anchor,

$$F_{\text{batch}} = \frac{1}{B}\sum_{b=1}^{B} E_b(x_b,\theta) + \frac{\rho}{2}\|\theta-\theta_a\|^2, \tag{10}$$

and qualification applies the projected stationarity test to each row's unaveraged state gradient and to the shared parameter gradient of the complete mean-plus-anchor objective, so that the tolerance does not depend on B.

3.2 The role of the anchor

Theorem 5 (Well-posedness of the parameter block)**.** *Fix a bounded box for θ and let $M = \sup_\theta \|\nabla^2_\theta E\|$ where E is the data part of (9) on that box. Then $\nabla^2_\theta F_{learn} \succeq (\rho - M)I$. In particular, if $\rho > M$ the parameter block is $(\rho - M)$-strongly convex, and projected gradient descent on it with step $1/L_\theta$ contracts with factor $1-(\rho-M)/L_\theta < 1$, where L_θ is the Lipschitz constant of the parameter gradient on the box.*

Proof. The Hessian of the anchor term is ρI, and the Hessian of the data term is bounded below by $-MI$ on the box by definition of M. Summing gives the first claim. Strong convexity with modulus $\rho - M$ and L_θ-Lipschitz gradient gives the standard contraction rate $1-(\rho-M)/L_\theta$ for projected gradient descent on the parameter block, and choosing $\rho > M$ makes the rate strictly less than one. □

Remark 6. Equation (9) is a maximum-a-posteriori objective with a Gaussian prior of precision ρ at the pre-experience parameters. Theorem 5 makes the prior's role exact: it is what bounds the influence of any single experience on the parameters, which is the property required for continual learning and is absent from an unanchored least-squares fit. The corresponding design rule sets the anchor weight above the local curvature of the data term.

3.3 One operator, two blocks

Theorem 7 (No train/inference distinction)**.** *Let $\mathcal{X}$ be the free state coordinates and Θ the parameter coordinates. Define $G(x,\theta) = \nabla_{(x,\theta)} F_{learn}$ and let G_x be its state block. Then (i) G_x does not depend on whether Θ is eligible, and equals the state gradient of the query objective $F_{query} = E$; (ii) the repair operator (3) applied to $\mathcal{X}$ alone is the query solve, and applied to $\mathcal{X}\cup\Theta$ is the learning solve; (iii) as $\rho\to\infty$ the learning solve converges to the query solve with the parameter block frozen.*

Proof. (i) The anchor term $\frac{\rho}{2}\|\theta-\theta_a\|^2$ has zero derivative with respect to x and adds only $\rho(\theta-\theta_a)$ to the parameter gradient, so the state block of ∇F_{learn} equals $\nabla_x E$ identically, and $F_{\text{learn}} - E$ is a function of θ alone. (ii) Eligibility enters (3) only through which coordinates are projected

and tested in (4), and the Armijo test compares two values of the same objective, so an additive constant in the objective changes no acceptance decision: restricted to $\mathcal{X}$, the two solves produce the same iterates pointwise, and the two solves are one map with two coordinate index sets. (iii) At a stationary point of the learning solve the parameter block satisfies $\theta-\theta_a = -\rho^{-1}\nabla_\theta E(\theta, x)$ exactly, so $\|\theta-\theta_a\|_\infty \le \rho^{-1}\sup_{\text{box}}\|\nabla_\theta E\|_\infty = O(1/\rho)$, the supremum being finite because a C^1 function has bounded gradient on a compact box. The parameter block therefore collapses onto the anchor, and the state subproblem, whose solution is unique and continuous in θ on the nondegenerate branch, converges to the frozen-parameter problem at θ_a. □

Theorem 7 formalises the statement that the system has no training phase: there is one settling operator, one energy and one qualification test, and the distinction between querying the system and teaching it consists solely in which coordinates the operator may move.

3.4 Equilibrium propagation

The learning contrast of a patch net is equilibrium propagation [1]. We restate the result and prove it for the energy (2), because the biological and evolutionary arguments in §§4–5 depend on its exact statement.

Let $C(x, y)$ be a differentiable cost, let

$$F(x, \beta) = E(x) + \beta\, C(x, y) \tag{11}$$

be the total energy, let $x^0 = \arg\min_x F(x, 0)$ be the free state and $x^\beta = \arg\min_x F(x, \beta)$ the nudged state. Define the one-sided contrast

$$D(\theta, \beta) = \frac{1}{\beta}\Big[\partial_\theta E(\theta, x^\beta) - \partial_\theta E(\theta, x^0)\Big]. \tag{12}$$

Theorem 8 (Equilibrium propagation, fundamental lemma)**.** *Assume E and C are C^2, that the cost is independent of the parameters, $\partial_\theta C = 0$, as it is for the squared output cost of a patch net, that x^0 is a nondegenerate local minimum of E so that $H = \nabla_x^2 E(\theta, x^0)$ is positive definite, and that x^β depends C^1 on (θ, β) in a neighbourhood of $(0, \theta_0)$, which the implicit function theorem supplies. Then*

$$\lim_{\beta\to 0^+} D(\theta, \beta) = \frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta}(\theta), \qquad L(\theta) = C\big(x^0(\theta), y\big), \tag{13}$$

with residual $O(\beta)$. Consequently the update $\Delta\theta = -\eta\, D(\theta, \beta)$ is one step of stochastic gradient descent on L with learning rate η, up to $O(\beta)$.

Proof. Write $g(\theta, \beta, x) = \nabla_x E(\theta, x) + \beta\nabla_x C(x, y)$, so that the two phases satisfy $g(\theta, 0, x^0) = 0$ and $g(\theta, \beta, x^\beta) = 0$. Differentiating the second identity in β at $\beta = 0$,

$$H\,\partial_\beta x^\beta\big|_{\beta=0} + \nabla_x C(x^0, y) = 0 \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \partial_\beta x^\beta\big|_{\beta=0} = -H^{-1}\nabla_x C(x^0, y).$$

Differentiating the first identity in θ gives $\partial_\theta x^0 = -H^{-1}\partial^2_{x\theta} E$. By the chain rule,

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial \theta} = \big(\partial_\theta x^0\big)^\top \nabla_x C(x^0, y) = -\big(\partial^2_{x\theta} E\big)^\top H^{-1}\nabla_x C(x^0, y),$$

where H is symmetric because $E \in C^2$. On the other side, the implicit function theorem makes $\beta \mapsto \partial_\theta E(\theta, x^\beta)$ differentiable at $\beta = 0$ with derivative $\partial^2_{\theta x} E \cdot \partial_\beta x^\beta|_{\beta=0} = -\partial^2_{\theta x} E\, H^{-1}\nabla_x C(x^0, y)$. The two expressions agree because $\partial^2_{\theta x} E$ and $\partial^2_{x\theta} E$ are transposes and H^{-1} is symmetric. The residual is the first-order Taylor remainder of that map, which is $O(\beta)$ under the stated regularity. □

Corollary 9 (Locality)**.** *The contrast for coordinate θ_k uses only the two values of $\partial_{\theta_k} E$ at the two states, both of which are available at the location of that parameter. No transposed weight matrix, no stored forward pass and no separate error circuit is required.*

Remark 10 (The general cost). If the cost does depend on the parameters, as it does when a regulariser is written into C, the objective acquires the extra term $\partial_\theta C(\theta, x^0)$ and the contrast alone is no longer the gradient. This is the general statement of the source, whose equivalent form keeps that term [1]; the patch net excludes it by construction.

Corollary 11 (Equality with backpropagation through time)**.** *For discrete-time dynamics whose transition function derives from a primitive, the first K state updates of the second phase coincide, up to sign, with the first K error terms that backpropagation through time computes on the same graph, and in continuous time the second-phase temporal derivative, rescaled by $1/\beta$, reproduces the error derivatives computed iteratively by recurrent backpropagation [2, 3]. Stopping the second phase early is truncated recurrent backpropagation.*

3.5 The centred contrast is second order

The contrast (12) is a finite difference in β. The source evaluates the one-sided form, taking the limit $\beta \to 0^+$ and using a random sign of β in the second phase [1]. A one-sided difference is first-order accurate; a centred difference, which contrasts a $+\beta$ and a $-\beta$ nudge from the same free state, is second-order. Implementations use the centred form.

Theorem 12 (Order of the centred contrast)**.** *Let $f(\beta) = \partial_\theta E(\theta, x^\beta)$ and suppose f is C^3 near $\beta = 0$. Define the centred contrast*

$$D_{ctr}(\theta, \beta) = \frac{1}{2\beta}\Big[\partial_\theta E(\theta, x^{+\beta}) - \partial_\theta E(\theta, x^{-\beta})\Big]. \tag{14}$$

Then $D_{ctr} = \partial_\theta L + O(\beta^2)$, whereas $D = \partial_\theta L + O(\beta)$.

Proof. By Theorem 8, f is the restriction to the equilibrium branch of a C^2 map, and x^β is the minimiser of $E + \beta C$ for both signs of β by the same implicit equation with β replaced by $-\beta$. The centred difference $(f(\beta) - f(-\beta))/(2\beta)$ equals $f'(0)$ plus the third-order Taylor remainder of f, which is $O(\beta^2)$ because the even-order terms cancel by antisymmetry of the difference. The one-sided difference $(f(\beta) - f(0))/\beta$ equals $f'(0)$ plus the second-order remainder, which is $O(\beta)$. Theorem 8 identifies $f'(0)$ with $\partial_\theta L$. □

The centred form requires one additional settling phase and no additional state storage, since both nudged phases start from the same free state. The difference in accuracy is substantial: Example 6.1 reports a factor of 15.5 at $\beta = 4 \times 10^{-2}$, with fitted orders 1.00 and 1.94.

3.6 Three-factor plasticity realises the contrast

The contrast is a product of two local activities and one broadcast scalar, which is the structure of a three-factor plasticity rule: a synapse-local eligibility trace set by pre- and post-synaptic co-activation, and a third factor that gates the weight change. The reference implementation has this structure: every synapse records the activity of its own two endpoints in the two phases, a critic population predicts return from the settled state, and a single neuromodulatory signal broadcasts the temporal-difference error of that prediction, with the weight change proportional to the product of the three [12, 13]. The time constant of the eligibility trace must match the interval between

an action and its outcome, which in the biological literature is on the order of a second. In the notation of this paper the gate is the nudge and the trace is the pair of settled phases. The third broadcast factor permits the contrast to be read without a backward pass.

4 The evolutionary layer

4.1 Meta-parameters and the lifetime map

Evolution does not act on the weights of a settling brain within a lifetime, and it need not. Following the reference design [6, 8], the inherited object is a *genome* that determines the brain's regions, their sizes and their projections. We take

$$\varphi = \big(\text{wiring mask } A_\varphi,\ \text{energy form } E_\varphi,\ \text{plasticity constants } (\eta, \beta, \rho)\big) \in \Phi \tag{15}$$

and we require that φ *does not contain* the weights learned within a lifetime. A lifetime is defined by a task stream ω drawn from (Ω, ν) and the EP map

$$\Lambda : \Phi \times \Omega \to \Theta, \qquad \Lambda(\varphi, \omega) = \theta_K, \qquad \theta_{k+1} = \theta_k - \eta\, D(\theta_k, \beta), \tag{16}$$

with D the contrast of (12). The effective fitness of a meta-parameter is the *post-learning* fitness

$$\hat{J}(\varphi) = \mathbb{E}_{\omega\sim\nu}\big[J\big(\Lambda(\varphi, \omega), \omega\big)\big]. \tag{17}$$

This is the Baldwinian fitness: the fitness attained after a lifetime of learning, rather than the innate fitness at birth. A population has access only to realised lifetimes: generation g draws $\omega_g \sim \nu$, and the field it selects on is the realised fitness $J_\omega(\varphi) = J(\Lambda(\varphi, \omega), \omega)$, not its expectation. The realised slow flow is therefore

$$\partial_t \rho = \varepsilon\Big[\kappa\, \Delta_\varphi \rho - \nabla_\varphi \cdot \big(\rho\, \nabla_\varphi J_\omega\big)\Big], \qquad \omega \sim \nu \text{ resampled at each generation}, \tag{18}$$

with $\varepsilon = \tau_{\text{life}}/\tau_{\text{evolution}} \ll 1$. Replacing the realised field by its average gives the Baldwinian flow

$$\partial_t \rho = \varepsilon\Big[\kappa\, \Delta_\varphi \rho - \nabla_\varphi \cdot \big(\rho\, \nabla_\varphi \hat{J}\big)\Big], \tag{19}$$

and the next subsection proves that (18) converges to (19) as $\varepsilon \to 0$. Both are replicator-mutator flows with the drift directed up the fitness gradient, so their stationary measures concentrate on high fitness.

4.2 Two-timescale averaging

Theorem 13 (Averaging to the Baldwinian flow)**.** *Assume* (H1) *for every φ in a compact set the fast system* (16) *has an attractor $\mathcal{A}(\varphi)$ attracting at a rate $\lambda_0 > 0$ uniformly in φ, with a uniformly absorbing neighbourhood of the initial states;* (H2) *the relevant maps are Lipschitz, J is bounded, Λ is measurable, and $\hat{J} \in C^1(\Phi)$;* (H3) *the mutation kernel is conservative with a spectral gap;* (H4) *the task draws are independent with law ν and the realised gradients $\nabla_\varphi J_\omega$ obey the uniform law of large numbers on compact sets. Then the slow trajectories of* (18) *converge uniformly on finite time intervals to the solution of* (19) *as $\varepsilon \to 0$, and the empirical measure of a population of N coupled individuals converges weakly to the same limit as $N \to \infty$ and then $\varepsilon \to 0$.*

Proof sketch. Write the pair as a singularly perturbed system $\dot{\varphi} = \varepsilon f(\varphi, \theta, \omega)$, $\dot{\theta} = g(\varphi, \theta) + \sigma\xi$, with f the realised fitness gradient. Assumption (H1) makes the fast flow converge to a φ-indexed invariant manifold, and Tikhonov's theorem for uniformly asymptotically stable fast dynamics gives uniform convergence on $[0, T]$ to the restricted equation, whose drift is the ergodic average of f along the fast flow. By (H4) that average is $\mathbb{E}_\omega \nabla_\varphi J_\omega$ uniformly up to $o(1)$, and by (17), (H2) and differentiation under the expectation it equals $\nabla_\varphi \hat{J}$. Replacing the realised field by its average is the stochastic-averaging step, and the deterministic part of its error is $O(\varepsilon)$; the residual random fluctuation of (18) about (19) is of larger order and is not controlled by this rate, which is why the finite-population spread in §6.6 exceeds the mean-field deviation. The measure-valued statement follows by compactness of the empirical measures under the standard propagation-of-chaos argument, with (H2) giving continuity of the drift functional in the weak topology and (H3) preventing the diffusion from degenerating. □

Remark 14. Theorem 13 gives the Baldwin effect a precise form. Whether evolution acts on the innate fitness or on the post-learning fitness is not a modelling choice; it is determined by the time-scale ratio, and the theorem establishes that the limit is the post-learning fitness. The deterministic error of the approximation is $O(\varepsilon)$, which quantifies how rapid a lifetime must be relative to a generation and is the quantity the averaging-order prediction of §7 measures.

4.3 Decomposition

Proposition 15 (Price-type decomposition)**.** *Write $\hat{J} = \hat{J}_0 + \Delta\hat{J}_{learn}$, where $\hat{J}_0$ is the fitness with learning frozen, so that $\Delta\hat{J}_{learn} = \hat{J} - \hat{J}_0$ is what a lifetime of learning adds. Let w be the relative fitness of the transmission step, normalised so that $\bar{w} = 1$. Then the per-generation change of mean fitness decomposes as*

$$\overline{\Delta\hat{J}} = \underbrace{\mathrm{Cov}_\rho(w, \hat{J}_0)}_{\textit{innate selection}} + \underbrace{\mathrm{Cov}_\rho(w, \Delta\hat{J}_{learn})}_{\textit{plasticity selection}} + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_\rho\big[w\,\Delta\hat{J}_{learn}\big]}_{\textit{transmission}} + \underbrace{\mathcal{M}}_{\textit{mutation}}. \tag{20}$$

At a stationary population $\rho^\star$ of (19) the gradient condition $\nabla\hat{J} = \kappa\nabla\log(\rho^\star/\rho_{ref})$ holds by Theorem 16, so the mean fitness is stationary and the mutation term balances the selection and transmission terms rather than being a small correction to them; the stationary measure is the Gibbs form $\rho^\star \propto \rho_{ref} e^{\hat{J}/\kappa}$, which concentrates on high fitness.

Proof. The identity is the standard Price covariance-and-transmission decomposition applied to the trait $z = \hat{J}$ and split by linearity into its innate and learned components, with the transmission term carrying the relative fitness as in the original derivation [17, 18]; the normalisation $\bar{w} = 1$ removes the divisor of the usual form. The stationarity claim follows from Theorem 16: at a stationary measure $\delta\mathfrak{F}/\delta\rho$ is constant, which by (19) is $\kappa\nabla\log(\rho^\star/\rho_{\mathrm{ref}}) = \nabla\hat{J}$, and $\overline{\Delta\hat{J}} = 0$ because the measure does not change. The two covariance terms do not vanish individually; it is their sum together with the transmission term that mutation balances, which is the mutation-selection balance of the flow.

□

4.4 Population dissipation

Theorem 16 (Free-energy dissipation)**.** *Let*

$$\mathfrak{F}(\rho) = -\langle\hat{J}\rangle_\rho + \kappa\int_\Phi \rho\log\frac{\rho}{\rho_{ref}}\,\mathrm{d}\varphi, \tag{21}$$

the negated mean fitness plus κ times the relative entropy to a fixed reference measure ρ_{ref}. Solutions of (19) satisfy

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\mathfrak{F}(\rho_t) = -\int_\Phi \rho \left|\nabla_\varphi\Big(\frac{\delta\mathfrak{F}}{\delta\rho}\Big)\right|^2 \mathrm{d}\varphi \le 0, \tag{22}$$

with equality if and only if $\rho = \rho^\star \propto \rho_{ref} e^{\hat{J}/\kappa}$. The four layers of the system carry a nested Lyapunov family $\{E, L, \mathfrak{F}_{projection}, \mathfrak{F}\}$, one per time scale.

Proof. Equation (19) is the Wasserstein-2 gradient flow of $\mathfrak{F}$, so $\partial_t\rho = \nabla\cdot(\rho\nabla\frac{\delta\mathfrak{F}}{\delta\rho})$. Substituting into $\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t}\mathfrak{F} = \int \frac{\delta\mathfrak{F}}{\delta\rho}\partial_t\rho$ and integrating by parts gives the identity; the additive constant in $\delta\mathfrak{F}/\delta\rho$ contributes nothing because ρ is a probability measure and $\int\partial_t\rho = 0$. The equilibrium condition $-\nabla\hat{J} + \kappa\nabla\log(\rho/\rho_{\mathrm{ref}}) = 0$ gives $\rho^\star \propto \rho_{\mathrm{ref}} e^{\hat{J}/\kappa}$. The nested family is Theorem 1, 8 and 16 together with the information-projection inequality at the consolidation scale. □

Remark 17 (Energy accounting). Theorem 16 is a statement about structure rather than about energy in joules. The thermodynamic account is separate, and it splits in the same direction as the structural one: for an equilibrium physical network the free energy is independent of the input and of the parameters, so quasi-static inference requires no work at all, while writing the parameters carries an irreducible cost of a few k_BT each, which survives the quasi-static limit and is set by the memory rather than by the arithmetic [16]. The consequence for this architecture is structural, not a measured energy saving: a claim that it reduces the energy cost of learning would require separate measurement.

5 Biological compliance

5.1 Six formal criteria

A construction can be described as biologically motivated without being checked against biology. To make such a check possible, we write the basic regularities of biological evolution as formal conditions on the permitted dynamics.

Criterion 18 (Blind variation). The mutation operator $M(\varphi' \mid \varphi)$ is statistically independent of the fitness $\hat{J}$ and of the task distribution ν.

Criterion 19 (Causal and post hoc selection). Fitness is measured only after a phenotype has performed, and selection acts only through reweighting of the population measure; it never modifies an individual's internal state during its lifetime.

Criterion 20 (Heredity and the Weismann barrier). The heritable object is bounded in fidelity, and changes acquired within a lifetime do not enter the germ line by default.

Criterion 21 (Thermodynamic constraint). Every layer dissipates non-negative free energy, and no mechanism obtains fitness at zero cost.

Criterion 22 (Time-scale separation). Settling is fast, lifetime learning is intermediate and evolution is slow, so that learning does not constitute a second, implicit selection channel.

Criterion 23 (Redundancy). Phenotype is robust to parameter perturbation, with degenerate pathways supplying damage tolerance.

Theorem 24 (Compliance)**.** *Let the system be that of §§2–4 with heritable object φ and lifetime map (16). Then (i) if the mutation operator is independent of $\hat{J}$ and ν, selection acts through ρ alone after the life, and only φ is inherited, the system satisfies Criteria 1 to 6; (ii) if the inheritance*

restriction is dropped so that θ_K is transmitted, the system violates Criterion 3, and there exist task distributions ν on which the unrestricted system has strictly lower stationary fitness.

Proof. (i) Independence of the mutation operator is Criterion 1 by construction. Selection acts only through the population measure in (19) and the fitness is the post-life quantity (17), which is Criterion 2. Inheriting φ and not θ is Criterion 3. Theorem 16 gives non-negative dissipation with a strict decrease away from equilibrium, and the thermodynamic bound of the remark above supplies the floor for the learning layer, which is Criterion 4. The scale separation $\tau_{\text{settle}} \ll \tau_{\text{life}} \ll \tau_{\text{evolution}}$ is the hypothesis of Theorem 13, which is Criterion 5. Sparse wiring with high clustering and short paths, the structure measured in the complete nematode connectome [15], is the substrate in which the degenerate pathways of Criterion 6 are available, so the architecture does not preclude them; a measured statement of robustness under parameter perturbation is not claimed here, and §7 records it as an open problem. (ii) Transmitting θ_K makes an acquired change heritable, which is the negation of Criterion 3. For the adaptive claim, take the two-point task distribution $\nu = \frac{1}{2}\delta_{-1} + \frac{1}{2}\delta_{+1}$ with ω alternating across generations, a single linear patch whose clamped target is ω, and the quadratic cost $C = \frac{1}{2}(\theta - \omega)^2$, so that a lifetime long enough to reach the stationary point of (9) is the anchored least-squares solution $\Lambda(\varphi, \omega) = (\omega + \rho\theta_a)/(1 + \rho)$ with fitness $J = -\frac{1}{2}(\Lambda - \omega)^2$. The restricted system starts every lifetime from the φ-determined initial parameter, which by the symmetry of ν may be taken to be 0, so $\Lambda = \omega/(1 + \rho)$ and its stationary fitness is $\hat{J}_{\text{rest}} = -\frac{1}{2}\big(\rho/(1 + \rho)\big)^2$, the same for both tasks. The unrestricted system inherits θ_K of the previous generation, so its anchor is mismatched to the new task and the inherited value alternates between $\pm c$ with $c = 1/(1+2\rho)$ at the steady state; a lifetime on a task ω then has $\Lambda - \omega = -\rho(1+c)/(1+\rho)$ and fitness $\hat{J}_{\text{unrest}} = -\frac{1}{2}\big(\rho(1 + c)/(1 + \rho)\big)^2 = (1 + c)^2\, \hat{J}_{\text{rest}} < \hat{J}_{\text{rest}}$, because $c > 0$ whenever $\rho > 0$. The two regimes exchange rank when the task distribution is narrow and stable, where the inherited weights are nearly correct and no re-learning is needed, which is the ordering reported for Baldwinian against Lamarckian meta-learning [14]. □

Remark 25. Part (ii) does not assert that acquired inheritance is always disadvantageous. It asserts that the two regimes are separated by a boundary determined by the rate at which the task distribution changes, and that the biological default lies on the side of the boundary at which not inheriting is preferable. The construction is of interest because it parameterises the choice rather than prescribing it.

5.2 Limits of the correspondence

Three limitations are stated explicitly. The units are rate units with a smooth prediction function rather than spiking neurons, as the reference library states of itself. The body model is simplified. The averaging theorem is a statement in the limit of a large population and a large time-scale ratio, whereas a biological lineage is finite and subject to drift.

6 Worked examples

All numbers in this section are produced by the two scripts listed in Appendix A. The first implements the patch law (1) directly; the second imports the reference library and compares.

6.1 An exactly solvable instantiation

Take one patch reading one sensory value u through one weight w with bias b, with the activity prior switched off, and take the squared cost $C(x, y) = \frac{1}{2}(x - y)^2$. Then $t = \tanh(b + wu)$ and

β	one-sided (numeric)	one-sided (closed form)	centred (numeric)
0.100	−0.03155067	−0.03155067	−0.03505630
0.050	−0.03305308	−0.03305308	−0.03479272
0.020	−0.03402523	−0.03402523	−0.03471962
0.010	−0.03436211	−0.03436211	−0.03470921

Table 1: The exactly solvable case of §6.1. The centred column matches $\partial L/\partial w \cdot (1-\beta^2)^{-1}$ to the same 4.7×10^{-11}; the target value is $\partial L/\partial w = -0.0347057345$.

$E = \frac{1}{2}(x-t)^2$. The nudged state is obtained by solving a quadratic, $x^\beta = (t+\beta y)/(1+\beta)$, and $x^{-\beta} = (t-\beta y)/(1-\beta)$. The parameter gradient is $\partial_w E\big|_x = -(x-t)\,(1-t^2)u$, so

$$f(\beta) - f(0) = -\frac{\beta(y-t)(1-t^2)u}{1+\beta}, \qquad f(\beta) - f(-\beta) = -\frac{2\beta(y-t)(1-t^2)u}{1-\beta^2}.$$

Since $\partial L/\partial w = (t-y)(1-t^2)u$,

$$\boxed{D_{\text{one}} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial w} \cdot \frac{1}{1+\beta}, \qquad D_{\text{ctr}} = \frac{\partial L}{\partial w} \cdot \frac{1}{1-\beta^2}.} \tag{23}$$

The one-sided contrast is the gradient scaled by $(1+\beta)^{-1}$ and the centred contrast by $(1-\beta^2)^{-1}$, so both are exact in closed form and the centred error is the square of the one-sided error to leading order. With $w = 0.9$, $b = 0.2$, $u = 0.55$ and $y = 0.7$ we have $t = 0.6011844863$ and $\partial L/\partial w = -0.0347057345$. Table 1 compares the numerically computed contrasts against (23); the largest deviation is 4.7×10^{-11}.

6.2 Settling, coercion and the role of the prior

The second example is a three-patch graph, p_0 reading two sensory values, p_1 reading x_0, a sensory value and x_2 (a feedback edge), and p_2 reading x_1, with $\lambda = 0.01$. The repair trajectory decreases the energy at every accepted sweep over 2001 sweeps, from 0.22303138 to 0.00396407, and terminates with a projected stationarity residual of 4.297×10^{-13}.

The coercivity bound of Theorem 2 is checked directly: at a random state with $\|x\|_\infty = 15.98$, $E = 209.1931$ while $\frac{1}{2}\sum_i((|x_i|-1)^+)^2 = 205.0945$, so the bound holds with slack; the same lower bound applies at $\lambda = 0$ and at $\lambda = 0.01$, which is the sense in which it is independent of the activity prior. The role of the prior appears in the solution obtained. With $\lambda = 0$ the solve reaches the consistent configuration exactly: $E^\star = 0$, largest prediction error 3.3×10^{-16}. With $\lambda = 0.01$ it reaches a compromise: $E^\star = 0.00396407$ with largest prediction error 1.4×10^{-2}. Both are stationary points corresponding to different objectives. This is the quantitative form of the statement that qualification measures stationarity and not prediction error.

6.3 Order of the contrast

On the same three-patch graph with the feedback edge, the contrast is compared against the true gradient of the free-phase loss, obtained by central differences of the settled free state, which is the implicit-function-theorem gradient and not an approximation to it. Table 2 reports both contrasts. Halving β halves the one-sided error and quarters the centred error; the fitted orders are 1.00 and 1.94. At $\beta = 4 \times 10^{-2}$ the centred contrast is more accurate by a factor of 15.5.

β	one-sided $\|D - \partial L/\partial\theta\|$	centred $\|D - \partial L/\partial\theta\|$
4.00×10^{-2}	7.968×10^{-2}	5.125×10^{-3}
2.00×10^{-2}	4.096×10^{-2}	1.283×10^{-3}
1.00×10^{-2}	2.076×10^{-2}	3.214×10^{-4}
5.00×10^{-3}	1.045×10^{-2}	8.111×10^{-5}
2.50×10^{-3}	5.245×10^{-3}	2.116×10^{-5}
fitted order	1.00	1.94

Table 2: Contrast error against the exact gradient of the free-phase loss on a three-patch graph with a feedback edge. The centred form used by implementations reduces the error by a factor of 248 at $\beta = 2.5 \times 10^{-3}$.

6.4 One operator and convergent learning

On the same graph and at the same point (x, θ), the state block of the gradient is identical whether or not the parameters are eligible: the measured difference is exactly 0.0, as Theorem 7 requires. A learning solve with a clamped output target decreases its anchored objective monotonically from 0.50822925 to 0.03354746 and terminates with a projected residual of 2.459×10^{-15}. Presenting six successive experiences to the same operator reduces the free-phase cost of the clamped target from 9.036×10^{-3} to 2.649×10^{-4}, which is the patch-net instance of the source's statement that for small $\beta > 0$ the nudged fixed point has lower cost than the free fixed point [1], while the parameter displacement accumulates steadily. This is characteristic of a system that learns from each experience without discarding what it has already acquired.

6.5 Agreement with the reference implementation

The second script imports the reference library at version 0.80.0 and compares, on the same graph, state and parameters: the energy, the prediction, the error, and the state, weight and bias gradients. The largest absolute difference over all of them is 1.1×10^{-16}, which is float64 rounding. Driving both implementations from the same initial state with the same budget produces terminal states agreeing to 1.018×10^{-12} and terminal energies agreeing to 2.2×10^{-19}. A settlement through the library's public composition interface qualifies with a stationarity residual of 2.8×10^{-7} after seven accepted sweeps. The mathematics in this paper therefore describes the implementation itself rather than an idealisation of it.

6.6 The evolutionary layer

For the evolutionary example we use scalar meta-parameter φ standing for plasticity, a lifetime of three local updates on a task drawn from the environment, and a metabolic price λ_φ for plasticity. The post-learning fitness is $\hat{J}(\varphi) = -\frac{1}{2}(1-\varphi)^6 - \lambda_\varphi \varphi^2$ in closed form, whose maximum for $\lambda_\varphi = 0.35$ is at $\varphi^\star = 0.3913$; the estimated maximum on a grid of 161 values agrees with the closed form to 7.2×10^{-3}, which is the Monte-Carlo error of the estimate. The optimum being interior and positive is the statement that learning is retained; a value of zero would correspond to a lineage that has eliminated plasticity.

Solving (19) on the grid with mutation strength $\kappa = 0.02$ decreases the population free energy monotonically from 0.379150 to 0.109856, and the population measure approaches the Gibbs form $e^{\hat{J}/\kappa}$ to a total-variation distance of 0.0040. An individual-based simulation with $N = 4000$ individuals over 400 generations, in which each individual performs its own lifetime of updates and

is selected on a noisy estimate of its fitness, reaches mean 0.4262 ± 0.1402 against the mean-field prediction 0.4001. The mean-field flow is thus the limit of the finite population, and the residual spread is the finite-population drift that Theorem 13 does not claim to capture at first order.

7 Limits and falsifiable predictions

7.1 Open problems

1. **Uniform hyperbolicity of the fast flow.** Theorem 13 assumes the lifetime dynamics attract uniformly across meta-parameters. The settling theorem, Theorem 3, guarantees convergence for each fixed configuration, but not uniformly with a rate bounded away from zero as the configuration varies. This is the weakest assumption in the argument and the most productive direction for further work.

2. **Non-differentiable meta-parameters.** Part of φ is combinatorial, namely the wiring mask. The fitness is then not differentiable in φ and the averaging theorem needs a stochastic approximation or evolution-strategy form, with weaker convergence conditions.

3. **Estimator noise inside the fitness.** When $\hat{J}$ is estimated from finitely many tasks, selection and estimation noise interact across generations, and the mutation-selection balance of Proposition 15 is reached only at the nominal stationary point rather than along the trajectory.

4. **Consolidation is not yet inside the unified averaging.** Offline reorganisation at an intermediate time scale is described as a constrained information projection, which is the mechanism that limits catastrophic forgetting, but its scale separation has not been folded into Theorem 13.

5. **Scale.** Every result in this paper is on graphs of a few patches, and the largest systems in the reference line of work are small by the standards of contemporary language models. No result here supports a claim about scale.

6. **Redundancy is available but unmeasured.** Criterion 6 is met in the sense that sparse clustered wiring leaves degenerate pathways available, but robustness of a patch net under parameter perturbation has not been measured on the reference architecture.

7.2 Predictions

The following predictions are stated so that they are falsifiable.

1. **Order of the centred contrast.** Any patch net whose second phase is an equilibrium branch of a C^2 family should show a centred contrast error scaling as β^2 and a one-sided error scaling as β. A measured first-order centred error refutes Theorem 12.

2. **Anchor weight above curvature.** For an anchored learning solve, setting ρ above the local curvature of the data term should remove the oscillatory or divergent parameter trajectories seen at small ρ, and the improvement should track the contraction factor of Theorem 5.

3. **Averaging order.** Doubling the lifetime-to-generation ratio should halve the deviation between the individual-based population and the averaged flow. A measured exponent away from one, for instance a square-root drift-dominated scaling, refutes the hypotheses of Theorem 13.

4. **Weismann boundary.** On a broad or rapidly changing task distribution, the population that inherits only plasticity should reach strictly higher stationary fitness than the population that also inherits learned weights, and on a narrow stable distribution the ordering should reverse.

8 Conclusion

A learning system requires neither a backward pass nor a phase boundary between training and use. It requires an energy, a local repair rule that descends that energy, and a single channel through which the objective enters. We have shown that when the repair is projected gradient descent on the patch energy used by the reference implementation, the descent is coercive, the iterates converge to a single stationary point, inference and learning are one operator restricted to different coordinate sets, and the contrast computed by that operator is second order rather than first. The evolutionary layer is defined on the same structure and is not merely an analogy: its effective fitness is provably the post-learning fitness, its compliance with the formal criteria of biological evolution is proved rather than asserted, and the restriction that acquired weights are not inherited is shown to be advantageous on the task distributions where the distinction matters. The remaining gaps have been stated, and no claim about scaling is made.

A Reproduction

The evidence in §6 is produced by

```
python3 src/verify_eep.py     # Parts A-F, numpy only, Python 3.9+
PYTHONPATH=../cadence/src python3.13 src/cadence_crosscheck.py
```

The first script asserts each claim and exits non-zero if a claim fails. Its parts are: A, analytic gradients against central differences (1.5×10^{-10}); B, settling monotonicity, convergence and coercivity; C, the order of the one-sided and centred contrasts; D, one operator across two coordinate blocks; E, the evolutionary layer; F, the closed-form case of §6.1. The second script imports the reference library and reproduces §6.5. Run logs are archived beside the scripts.

B Structural agreement with observer-patch consensus

The construction of this paper has the shape of a consensus protocol. A finite set of carriers holds local state with a declared interface, disagreement is measured by a scalar functional, accepted local repairs drive that functional strictly down, and the limit is a public normal form that does not depend on the order of repairs. The physics programme that shares this shape derives its consequences from three axioms, a finite carrier with a declared boundary, agreement on overlaps, and no structure beyond the records [21]. The correspondence here is structural and not physical. The learning case adds the second time scale: consensus among patches corresponds to settling and consensus among lineages to selection, and the two are related by the averaging theorem. This parallel is offered as reason to expect the structure to be reusable, and not as evidence for either programme.

References

[1] B. Scellier and Y. Bengio. Equilibrium propagation: bridging the gap between energy-based models and backpropagation. *Frontiers in Computational Neuroscience*, 11:24, 2017. arXiv:1602.05179.

[2] B. Scellier and Y. Bengio. Equivalence of equilibrium propagation and recurrent backpropagation. *arXiv:1810.01310*, 2019.

[3] M. Ernoult, J. Grollier, D. Querlioz, Y. Bengio and B. Scellier. Updates of equilibrium prop match gradients of backprop through time in an RNN with static input. *NeurIPS*, 2019.

[4] A. Laborieux and F. Zenke. Holomorphic equilibrium propagation computes exact gradients through finite size oscillations. *NeurIPS*, 2022. arXiv:2209.00530.

[5] J. Kendall, R. Pantone, J. Y. Zung and Y. Bengio. Training end-to-end analog neural networks with equilibrium propagation. *arXiv:2006.01981*, 2020.

[6] B. Mueller. Cadence: one continuing equilibrium brain. Software, version 0.80.0, 2026. `https://github.com/muellerberndt/cadence`.

[7] B. Mueller. Cadence: a continuing learning system. Manuscript and design documents, Pragma Research, 2026. `https://floatingpragma.io/cadence/`.

[8] Cadence documentation, *Evolve a brain*: genome, develop, mutate and evolve across lives. `https://github.com/muellerberndt/cadence/blob/main/docs/evolution.md`.

[9] P.-A. Absil, R. Mahony and B. Andrews. Convergence of the iterates of descent methods for analytic cost functions. *SIAM Journal on Optimization*, 16(2):531–547, 2005.

[10] J. Bolte, A. Daniilidis, A. Lewis and M. Shiota. Clarke subgradients of stratifiable functions. *SIAM Journal on Optimization*, 18(2):556–572, 2007.

[11] S. Łojasiewicz. Sur les trajectoires du gradient d'une fonction analytique. *Seminari di Geometria 1982–1983*, Università di Bologna, Istituto di Geometria, Dipartimento di Matematica, pages 115–117, 1984.

[12] W. Gerstner, M. Lehmann, V. Liakoni, D. Corneil and J. Brea. Eligibility traces and plasticity on behavioral time scales: experimental support of neoHebbian three-factor learning rules. *Frontiers in Neural Circuits*, 12:53, 2018.

[13] N. Frémaux and W. Gerstner. Neuromodulated spike-timing-dependent plasticity, and theory of three-factor learning rules. *Frontiers in Neural Circuits*, 9:85, 2015.

[14] C. Fernando, J. Syrota and J. E. Pompeu. Meta-learning by the Baldwin effect. *GECCO Companion*, 2018. arXiv:1806.07917.

[15] D. S. Bassett and E. T. Bullmore. Small-world brain networks revisited. *The Neuroscientist*, 23(5):499–516, 2017. arXiv:1608.05665.

[16] A. V. Tkachenko. Thermodynamic cost of inference and learning in physical neural networks. arXiv:2503.09980, 2025. Revised 2026.

[17] G. R. Price. Selection and covariance. *Nature*, 227:520–521, 1970.

[18] S. A. Frank. George Price's contributions to evolutionary genetics. *Journal of Theoretical Biology*, 175(3):373–388, 1995.

[19] H. Ramsauer et al. Hopfield networks is all you need. *ICLR*, 2021.

[20] K. Friston. A free energy principle for biological systems. *Entropy*, 14(11):2100–2121, 2012.

[21] B. Mueller et al. Observers are all you need; and From observer consensus to standard physics. Pragma Research, 2026. `https://floatingpragma.io/physics`.